The Paris Agreement and the COP Process

> Part of the Functional Series. The Paris Agreement is the framework the rest of this series measures itself against. This document sets out what the Agreement actually commits countries to, how its five-year cycle works, and what the COP meetings since 2015 have added. The targets are turned into numbers in the next document.
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> **As of:** the Agreement's authentic text; UNEP *Emissions Gap Report 2025* (data to 30 September 2025); reporting on the COP30 decision of 22 November 2025. Later submissions and decisions are not reflected.

1. What the Agreement says

The Agreement was adopted in Paris on 12 December 2015. The wording below is from the authentic text deposited with the UN Secretary-General.

Article	What it provides
2.1(a)	Hold the global average temperature increase to "well below 2°C above pre-industrial levels and pursuing efforts to limit the temperature increase to 1.5°C"
2.1(b), (c)	Increase the ability to adapt; make finance flows consistent with a low-emission, climate-resilient pathway
4.1	Reach "global peaking of greenhouse gas emissions as soon as possible" and then rapid reductions, to "achieve a balance between anthropogenic emissions by sources and removals by sinks of greenhouse gases in the second half of this century"
4.2	Each Party "shall prepare, communicate and maintain successive nationally determined contributions" (NDCs) and pursue domestic measures to achieve them
4.3	Each successive NDC "will represent a progression beyond the Party's then current" one and "reflect its highest possible ambition"
4.4	Developed countries should lead with economy-wide absolute reduction targets; developing countries are encouraged to move towards such targets over time
4.9	Each Party communicates an NDC **every five years**
14	A **global stocktake** of collective progress, first in 2023 and every five years after, informing the next round of NDCs
21	Entry into force once at least 55 Parties covering at least 55% of global emissions had ratified
28	A Party may withdraw at any time after three years from entry into force for it; withdrawal takes effect one year after notification

Three features shape everything that follows:

1. **The goals are collective; the commitments are national.** The temperature limits are global. Each country sets its own NDC, and the Agreement requires it to *pursue measures* to achieve it, not to *achieve* it.

2. **There is no legal quantity each country must reach.** Ambition is meant to rise through a five-year ratchet, driven by the stocktake and by transparency about progress.
3. **The temperature goal is stated against "pre-industrial levels".** The IPCC and this platform's data both take that as 1850–1900, and the IPCC reports global warming as running 20-year averages, so the goal concerns the long-term level, not any single year.

2. The five-year cycle

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2015  Agreement adopted
2020  NDC round (targets mainly for 2030)
2023  Global stocktake (concluded at COP28)
2025  NDC round (targets typically for 2035)
2028  Global stocktake
2030  NDC round (targets typically for 2040)
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The cycle matters for reading the platform's results: the **2030 NDCs** are the targets the platform's scenarios run past, and the **2035 NDCs** are the first that were designed after the stocktake showed how large the gap was.

3. What the COP meetings have added

The Agreement is deliberately short; the detail lives in decisions taken at each Conference of the Parties.

Year	Meeting	Outcome relevant to this series
2021	COP26 Glasgow	A goal to double adaptation finance, to $40 billion by 2025, was set (reaffirmed at COP30)
2023	COP28 Dubai	**First global stocktake.** It reaffirmed the science that 1.5 °C pathways require deep, rapid and sustained cuts of **43% by 2030 and 60% by 2035** from 2019 levels and net-zero CO_2 by 2050, and called on countries to contribute to global efforts including tripling renewable energy capacity, doubling the rate of energy-efficiency improvement by 2030, and **"transitioning away from fossil fuels in energy systems"**
2024	COP29 Baku	A new collective climate-finance goal: $300 billion a year by 2035, with an aspiration of $1.3 trillion
2025	COP30 Belém (decision adopted 22 November 2025)	The "Global Mutirão" decision acknowledged that the remaining carbon budget for 1.5 °C is "small and being rapidly depleted" and was the first COP text to acknowledge a likely **1.5 °C overshoot**. It called for tripling adaptation finance by 2035 and launched two voluntary initiatives (a global implementation accelerator and a "Belém mission to 1.5°C"). It did **not** contain a fossil-fuel or deforestation roadmap; the presidency announced two voluntary roadmaps outside the formal process

Sources for this table: the Agreement itself and, for the COP decisions, the IPCC Synthesis Report (for the 43% and 60% figures) and press and analyst reporting on the decision texts (for the COP28 wording and the COP30 outcome). The UNFCCC's own decision documents could not be retrieved automatically for this series, so the wording of the COP decisions should be checked against the official text before it is quoted.

4. Where the process stands (as of late 2025)

- **New NDCs were due in February 2025.** By 30 September 2025 only 64 Parties, covering 63% of global emissions, had submitted or announced new ones, and 60 of those contained 2035 targets (UNEP *Emissions Gap Report 2025*).
- **Net-zero pledges** now cover about 70% of global emissions, up from none in 2015 (UNEP).
- **The United States:** UNEP's November 2025 report states that the US NDC would no longer be in effect from 27 January 2026, as the US is withdrawing. The Agreement's own rule is that a withdrawal takes effect one year after notification (Article 28).
- **First transparency reports** under the Agreement's reporting framework have appeared, a first step towards comparable national reporting (UNEP).
- **The next formal checkpoint** is the second global stocktake in 2028, with dialogue sessions in 2026 and 2027 feeding it.

5. Reading the Agreement alongside this platform

The Agreement says	The platform can show
Hold warming to well below 2 °C, pursue 1.5 °C	The observed anomaly against 1850–1900 and its long-term level (Temperature)
Peak emissions as soon as possible, then decline	Whether each country's and the world's emissions have peaked
Net balance in the second half of the century	Not modelled: the platform's horizon is 2040
Progression of NDCs every five years	Which pledges exist; the platform does not forecast pledges

See also

- Targets as Numbers
- Country NDCs
- Pathways, Carbon Budgets and Warming Outlooks